Curriculum Vitae

Qian Cao

Department of Philosophy
Columbia University
1150 Amsterdam Ave,
New York, NY 10027 USA

e: qc2255@columbia.edu

Area of Specialization (AOS): Ancient Greek and Roman Philosophy, Psychoanalysis

Area of Competence (AOC): Ethics, Classical Chinese Philosophy, History of Early Modern Philosophy

EMPLOYMENT

COLUMBIA UNIVERSITY

Postdoctoral Research Scholar and Lecturer, the Initiative in Ancient and Contemporary Philosophy 2025-Present

EDUCATION

COLUMBIA UNIVERSITY

New York, NY

Ph.D. in Philosophy October 2025

Dissertation: Appearance and Reality—Plato and the Psychological Difficulties of Inquiry

Committee: Katja Vogt (Chair), Dhananjay Jagannathan, Achille Varzi, Francey Russell, Jessica Moss (external examiner)

Abstract ***(An extended version is attached at the end of the C.V.)***

What, for Plato, makes inquiry difficult? This question has been explored with a view to Plato's metaphysics. Our engrossment in the sense perceptible domain—characterized by its instability and deceptiveness—makes it difficult for us to attend to intelligible reality and often leads us astray. In addition, I argue, Plato is interested in the psychological challenges of inquiry. Moving from appearance to reality is hard not only because reality is difficult to grasp, but also because we have a tendency to thwart our best effort at seeing the world for what it is. I examine famous as well as neglected passages in *Cratylus*, *Republic*, and *Theaetetus*, and draw on psychoanalytic contributions that, in my view, help elucidate how Plato conceives of the conflation of appearances with reality. With a view to the *Cratylus*, I examine a phenomenon I call dizziness, where cognizers project their own changing states of mind onto the world and are thereby attracted to a Heraclitean version of relativism. With a view to Part I of the *Theaetetus*, I argue that Plato singles out present-tense sense perception and present-tense norms as limited domains where relativism can seem especially compelling. The end of Part II of the *Theaetetus*, I argue, offers an account of the deficiency of *doxa* (opinion) that appeals to the way in which views formed based on appearances are mistaken for knowledge. In the *Republic*, I turn to the distinctive kinds of imagination that poetry, as discussed in early and late books of the dialogue, speaks to. Turning to the middle books of the *Republic*, I offer a new interpretation of why Plato puts so much stock into mathematics as a component of the philosophers' education. Mathematics permits a kind of playfulness that is critical to attain for inquirers.

M.Phil. in Philosophy May 2021

M.A. in Philosophy May 2020

INSTITUTE FOR PSYCHOANALYTIC TRAINING AND RESEARCH (IPTAR)

New York, NY 2022-Present

Advanced candidate in the Adult Program & the Child and Adolescent Program (CAP)

NEW YORK UNIVERSITY
New York, NY
Bachelor of Arts in Philosophy May 2017

- **Honors**: Phi Beta Kappa, and High Honors in Philosophy
- **Honors Thesis***: Aristotle on the Voluntary and* Prohairesis—*Doing the Human Function Well Makes Us Maximally Free* (Advisor: Jessica Moss)

PAPERS

"Plato on Dizziness, Projection, and the Psychology of Relativism" (R&R)

"Mathematics, Play, and Reality in the *Republic*" (Under Review)

"Measure Doctrine and Immediate Sense Perception in the *Theaetetus*" (In Progress)

"Different Audience of Imitative Poetry: A Tale of Human Psychology in *Republic* Books 3 and 10" (In Progress)

"Guilt, Need for Punishment, and Moral Responsibility" (In Progress)

"Hide and Seek: The Wish to Be Sought and Found in the Treatment of a Latency-Aged Child" (In Progress)

FELLOWSHIP & AWARDS

2025-2028	Core Curriculum Postdoctoral Lectureship in Contemporary Civilization, Columbia University **Awarded. (Declined in order to accept the postdoctoral position with the Initiative in Ancient and Contemporary Philosophy)*
2024-2025	Core Curriculum Preceptorship in Contemporary Civilization, Columbia University
2022	Center for the Ancient Mediterranean Summer Research Fund ($1,000), Columbia University
2021-2022	Teaching Observation Fellowship, Center for Teaching & Learning, Columbia University
2019-2022	Benjamin Wolstein Fellowship, Columbia University
2021-2022	Columbia Tutor Corps Operations Fellow, Office of Public Affairs/Government & Community Affairs

PRESENTATIONS

April 2026	"Psychic Flux and Transformation in Plato," *The Meade Anderson Forum in Philosophy Conference*, Columbia University
March 2026	"Measure Doctrine and Immediate Sense Perception in the *Theaetetus*," Katja Vogt's graduate seminar on Aristotle and the Measure Doctrine, Columbia University
March 2026	"Hide and Seek: The Wish to Be Sought and Found in the Treatment of a Latency-Aged Child," *Rebecca Shaffer Memorial Lecture*, Institute for Psychoanalytic Training and Research (IPTAR)

Feb 2026 "Hans Loewald's 'Man as Moral Agent'," Invited Guest Lecture for *Living, Dying, and the Meaning of Life* class, Columbia University

Nov 2025 "Mathematics, Play and Reality in Plato's *Republic,*" APS Graduate Panel, *The Ancient Philosophy Society*

Aug 2025 "An Account of Why Perception Fails to Reach Truth and Being in the *Theaetetus*," *End-of-Summer Workshop*, Columbia University

Aug 2024 "Mathematics, Play, and Reality—on the Difficulty of Turning the Soul Around in the *Republic*", *Research Group in Ancient and Contemporary Philosophy*, Columbia University

July 2024 "Plato on Dizziness, Projection, and the Psychology of Relativism", *Athena in Action: A Networking and Mentoring Workshop for Graduate Student Women in Philosophy*, University of Notre Dame

March 2024 "Plato on Dizziness, Projection, and the Psychology of Relativism", *Keeling Graduate & Early Career Conference in Ancient Philosophy*, University College London, United Kingdom

Aug 2023 "Different Audience of Imitative Poetry: A Tale of Human Psychology in *Republic* 3 and 10", *End-of-Summer Workshop*, Columbia University

June 2023 "Collective Appearances, Individual *Psyche*, and Collective Responsibility", *The Aristotle-Confucius Symposium on Ethics for the 21st Century*, a week-long conference held at Academy of Athens and at Aristotle University of Thessaloniki

Oct 2022 "On the Difficulty of Turning the Soul Around in *Republic*", presentation in Katja Vogt's graduate seminar, Columbia University

July 2022 "Plato and the Appeal of Relativism", *Graduate Students Workshop*, University of Colorado, Boulder

Mar 2022 "Plato and the Appeal of Relativism", *Ancient Philosophy WIP Workshop*, New York University

Oct 2021 "The Meno Problem", guest lecture in Katja Vogt's undergraduate class, Columbia University

Aug 2021 "Plato on the Descriptive and Dynamic Use of Language", *Research Group in Ancient and Contemporary Philosophy*, Columbia University

Aug 2020 "Language and Reality in the *Cratylus*: Correctness as Imitation", *Research Group in Ancient and Contemporary Philosophy*, Columbia University

Aug 2019 "The Skeptics' Non-Doxastic Assent as an Alternative to Holding Dogmata—A Reading Through the Lens of Plato", *Research Group in Ancient and Contemporary Philosophy*, Columbia University

Jan 2019 (with Mariana Beatriz-Noe, Olivia Branscum, and Yarran Hominh) "Mutual Skill-Building through Undergraduate Writing Workshops", MAP Panel on Skill-Building and Improving the Profession, Eastern APA

INVITED COMMENTS

Oct 2022 Comment on Catherine Rowett, "Platonic Method", *Workshop in Ancient and Contemporary Philosophy*, Columbia University

Feb 2022 Comment on Amber Carpenter, "Ethics of Atomism", *Lecture Series of Center for the Ancient Mediterranean*, Columbia University

Mar 2021 Comment on Suzanne Obdrzalek, "Platonic Dualism Reconsidered", *Workshop in Ancient and Contemporary Philosophy*, Columbia University

April 2020 Comment on Molly Gordon Pinkoski, "Aristotelian Absolute Prohibitions", *in Dhananjay Jagannathan's graduate seminar*, Columbia University

Mar 2020 Comment on Hadassa Noorda, "Exprisonment: Deprivation of Liberty on the Street and at Home", *Munich-New York City Workshop in Ethics*, Columbia University

Mar 2019 Comment on Klaus Corcilius, "Cosmological ethics and internal order in the *Timaeus*", *Workshop in Ancient and Contemporary Philosophy*, Columbia University

Nov 2018 Comment on James Doyle, "No Morality: Modern Moral Philosophy (1958)", *Workshop in Ancient and Contemporary Philosophy*, Columbia University

TEACHING

Instructor of Record, Columbia University

Fall 2025	History of Philosophy I - Pre-Socratics through Augustine, Philosophy
Spring 2025	Contemporary Civilization II, Core Curriculum
Fall 2024	Contemporary Civilization I, Core Curriculum
Summer 2024	Ethics, Philosophy

Teaching Assistant (TA), Columbia University

Spring 2024	*Living, Dying, and the Meaning of Life* (Katja Vogt, Lydia Dugdale, and Ian Rottenberg)
Fall 2023	*History of Philosophy I - Pre-Socratics through Augustine* (Dhananjay Jagannathan)
Spring 2022	*History of Philosophy II - Medieval and Early Modern Philosophy* (Christina Van Dyke)
Fall 2021	*History of Philosophy I - Pre-Socratics through Augustine* (Katja Vogt)
Spring 2021	*Introduction to Philosophy* (Francey Russell)
Fall 2020	*Philosophy of Law* (Michele Moody-Adams)
Spring 2020	*Introduction to Philosophy* (Francey Russell)
Fall 2019	*Feminism and Philosophy* (Christia Mercer)

Co-Facilitator, *RETHINK***,** a Columbia philosophy community outreach program
Summer 2022

- Co-led a series of discussions centering around the theme of "Happiness" to a group of youth affected by the criminal legal system

Instructor of Record, *BIG QUESTIONS,* a NYU-led outreach program for high schools
2015 – 2018

- Led weekly philosophy discussion in both English and Mandarin for a group of 20 high school students;
- Led discussion on "Big Questions," including freedom and determinism, Responsibility and Determinism, Personal Identity, Happiness, Equality, Right and Wrong, and Animal Rights;
- Helped students to articulate, defend, and adjust their ideas in rational and respectful debate;
- Designed lesson plans to introduce students to philosophical questions in Confucian ethics

PEDAGOGICAL TRAINING

2020 Innovative Teaching Summer Institute (ITSI), Columbia Center for Teaching and Learning (CTL), Columbia University

2021-2022 As a Teaching Observation Fellow with Columbia Center for Teaching and Learning (CTL), I worked closely other fellows from different disciplines to build skills in teaching observation, formative assessment, inclusive teaching, and peer mentorship.

SERVICE TO THE PROFESSION

2024-2026 Referee for *Archiv für Geschichte der Philosophie*

2023-2026 Referee for *Noûs*

2020-2023 Assistant Managing Editor for North America, *Archiv für Geschichte der Philosophie*

2021-2022 Graduate Student Representative, Columbia University Philosophy Department

2018-2022 Co-organizer, Columbia University MAP (Minority and Philosophy) Chapter

2018-2022 Organizer, Non-Western Philosophy Reading Group, Columbia University

2021 Organizer, "Life of a Paper" talk series, Columbia University Philosophy Department

2018-2021 Workshop leader of the *Reading & Writing Philosophy Workshop*, organized by the Minorities and Philosophy (MAP) chapter, Columbia University

2019 Co-organizer, Columbia-NYU Graduate Conference in Philosophy

2018 Judge, NYC High School Ethics Bowl

GRADUATE COURSEWORK

**indicates audit*

Ancient Philosophy

Plato's *Republic*, Katja Vogt
Protagoras, Wolfgang Mann
Hellenistic Philosophy: Ancient Relativism and Skepticism, Katja Vogt
Aristotelian Naturalisms, Dhananjay Jagannathan
Plato, Katja Vogt
*** Early Stoic Philosophy: Logic, Physics, and Ethics**, Katja Vogt
Plato's *Timaeus*, Katja Vogt
*** Practical Wisdom in Plato and Aristotle**, Jessica Moss and Iakovos Vasiliou (NYU)
*** Plato**, Jessica Moss (NYU)
Democracy and Its Discontents in Late Fifth-century Athens, Elizabeth Scharffenberger (Classics)
*** Aristotle**, Katja Vogt
*** Ancient Epistemology**, Jessica Moss (NYU)
Theophrastus, Wolfgang Mann
*** Lucretius**, Wolfgang Mann

Other Courses

Self-Knowledge, Akeel Bilgrami
Self-Opacity and Human Agency, Francey Russell
Symbolic Logic, Tamar Lando
Metaethics: What, if Anything, Is Morality?, Katja Vogt
Democratic Citizenship: Problems and Possibilities, Michele Moody-Adams
*** Kant**, Patricia Kitcher
Kant's Ethics, Patricia Kitcher
Feminist, Social, and Political Philosophy of Language, Karen Lewis
Metaethics: **The Value of Truth**, Katja Vogt
Boundaries — from Politics to Metaphysics (and back), Achille Varzi
Heidegger, Taylor Carman
*** Buddhist Ethics**, Graham Priest (CUNY)
*** Classical Chinese Philosophy**, Hagop Sakissian (CUNY)

LANGUAGES

Ancient: Greek (scholarly proficient), Classical Chinese (intermediate)

Modern: English (fluent), Mandarin Chinese (fluent), Italian (intermediate)

REFERENCES

Katja Vogt, Professor of Philosophy, Columbia University
kv2101@columbia.edu

Jessica Moss, Professor of Philosophy, New York University
jm5706@nyu.edu

Amber Carpenter, Professor of Ancient Philosophy, Oxford University
amber.carpenter@philosophy.ox.ac.uk

Michele Moody-Adams, Professor of Philosophy, Columbia University
mm3735@columbia.edu

Dhananjay Jagannathan, Associate Professor of Philosophy, Hunter College — City University of New York
dhananjay.jagannathan@hunter.cuny.edu

Dissertation Abstract

Title: Appearance and Reality—Plato and the Psychological Difficulties of Inquiry

The core question that motivates this dissertation is the appearance and reality distinction in Plato's work. Traditionally, this distinction is treated as a metaphysical distinction by Plato scholars. While there's a lot of literature on this, I look at it from a different perspective. I argue that for Plato, this isn't just a theoretical problem—it's also a psychological one. That is to say, moving from appearance to reality is a deeply difficult psychological task. To shed light on this difficulty, I draw on psychoanalytic literature.

In "Two Principles of Mental Functioning," Freud offers an account of how an essentially pleasure-seeking psyche comes to be regulated by the reality principle. Plato, I argue, is similarly interested in how a psyche that starts off embedded in appearances comes to appreciate the distinction between appearance and reality. Both Freud and Plato, in different ways, investigate how true and false judgments, that is, the capacity to decide whether an idea is in agreement with reality, emerge in human cognition. Drawing on Freud's insight that this is a developmental milestone that could come undone when the psyche is under strain, I argue that Plato, too, is interested in moments where the distinction between appearance and reality becomes tenuous, if not non-existent, to the effect that it is difficult for the cognizer to see reality for what it is.

Methodologically, I engage with psychoanalytic theories to the extent that they illuminate Plato's own views, particularly shedding light on aspects of his moral psychology that have been relatively overlooked thus far. In terms of the range of dialogues, I focus on the *Cratylus* and *Theaetetus*, which showcase Plato's extensive engagement with relativism, and the *Republic*, which articulates his revisionist idea of education as "turning the soul around."

Chapters 1 and 2 examine Plato's *diagnosis* of the tenuous distinction between appearance and reality in judgment, while chapters 3 and 4 explore his proposed *solutions* to this problem.

In chapter 1, I argue that the Plato of the *Theaetetus*—like the Pyrrhonean skeptics—is especially attuned to the danger of dogmatism that resides in making judgments on the basis of mere seemings/appearances. I build on debates about the skeptics' non-doxastic assent as well as two bodies of scholarship on the *Theaetetus*: whether Plato's engagement with relativism and Heraclitean metaphysics ultimately aims to confirm his own, earlier, metaphysical commitments; and how we should construe his discussion of false *doxa* in Part II of the dialogue. At the end of Part II, Socrates argues that perception (*aisthêsis*) fails to grasp truth and being. I side with interpreters who take this to resonate with ideas from the *Republic*. Against existing accounts, I argue that this imports a distinctive kind of deficiency of *doxa* into the *Theaetetus*, a deficiency that is not immediately about falsity. As I interpret the *Republic*, *doxa* are judgments one makes on the basis of mere seemings/appearances. They are dysfunctional insofar as the cognizer mistakes them for knowledge (*epistêmê*). Doing so, the cognizer does not simply take something to be true that is false; rather, they fail to locate truth with being, and fail to see that sense-perception does not reach this domain. My argument has upshots both for the interpretation of Plato and for our reading of Pyrrhonian skepticism. Discussion of why Plato finds false *doxa* puzzling needs to include reflection on the metaphysics of truth and being in the *Republic*. The Pyrrhonean criticism of *dogmata* and their proposed alternative—non-doxastic assent to what is apparent—turn out to directly respond to Plato's concern with *doxa* as judgments on the basis of mere seemings/appearances.

In chapter 2, I turn to Plato's engagement with Protagorean relativism, which I take to be closely related to the Pyrrhonean criticism of *dogmata* and Plato's critique of *doxa* examined in the first chapter. I start by asking, why does Plato engage intensively with relativism, even though it seems clear that he is not a relativist? I argue that traditional accounts of Plato's interest in relativism overlook a fascinating dimension of his work. I defend the view that his engagement with relativism is motivated by his attempt to understand the psychology of relativism's attraction for us. I take seriously an idea from the *Cratylus* that has so far not received much

attention, namely, that the ancient name-givers became "dizzy" while searching for the nature of things and projected their dizziness onto the world (411b-c). I draw on the notion of projection qua defense mechanism in psychoanalytic literature in order to identify where the name-givers go wrong—they mistake what is coming from inside as coming from outside. I argue that although Plato does not formulate a theory of projection, he nevertheless recognizes it as an interesting psychological phenomenon. It allows the cognizer to "project" her dizziness onto the world, describing it as constantly changing, to the effect that all views about it are true. The projection is especially tempting in domains that are characterized by what Burnyeat describes in terms of "conflicting appearances." Relativism, moreover, fosters intellectual complacency. By denying the possibility of genuine disagreements and the need for further inquiry, the relativist has in fact abandoned the project of inquiry altogether. Understood as such, Plato's engagement with relativism alerts us to the danger of dogmatic laziness in the process of inquiry, which demands from the inquirer "courage" to tolerate the uncertainty and the frustration of not yet possessing knowledge.

Chapters 3 and 4 then consider his account of how the right kind of education—through imitative poetry and mathematics, respectively—might facilitate the psyche's movement beyond appearance toward intelligible reality. I argue that imitative poetry and mathematics each have a unique role to play in holding the *psyche* steady in the midst of conflicting appearances, especially about values.

In chapter 3, I offer an account of why poetry can serve a positive role in childhood education, even though it cannot do so in adulthood. I argue that Plato distinguishes between two stages in an agent's life, in which they are typically affected by poetry. With some simplification, these can be called childhood and adulthood. In childhood, poetry helps the child develop an aspirational outlook on their own life. This is facilitated by a psychological mechanism termed by Richard Wollheim as "central imagination," in which the agent identifies with the hero, and as a result, comes to feel what they imagine the character would feel. This mechanism is crucial for Plato, I argue, because it helps young children to gradually cultivate a "perspective" on the world. In adulthood, by contrast, poetry corrupts the rational part of the soul by strengthening the inferior part of the soul. This is facilitated through a psychological mechanism termed by Wollheim as "peripheral imagination," in which the audience sympathetically (or unsympathetically) responds to the experiences they take the hero to undergo. For example, they might feel either pity (or contempt) for the character. I show that versions of these two psychological mechanisms figure in Plato's account of poetry. The upshot is that (good) poetry is essential to the development and growth of young children. However, it should be regarded as a transitional tool—a ladder to be thrown away once the psyche is fully developed.

In chapter 4, I turn to mathematical education. I explore the nature of the difficulty involved in turning the soul around from the realm of sense perceptibles to that of intelligibles in the famous soul-turning metaphor in the *Republic*, and why Plato thinks that mathematics is uniquely suited to facilitate this transformation. I focus on an idea from the *Republic* that has thus far been overlooked: mathematics encourages an attitude which Socrates characterizes as "play" (535d). Drawing on Winnicott's notion of playing with reality, I show that mathematics—in virtue of its unique method and subject-matter—cultivates a kind of playfulness that disarms the cognizer's defensiveness around not yet possessing knowledge and hence facilitates open-ended inquiry.

In short, this dissertation examines the psychological difficulties that can get in the way of inquiry as identified by Plato, with a particular focus on the defective nature of *doxa*, and the psychological attractiveness of relativism. After articulating the psychological difficulties of inquiry, which Plato metaphorically terms "dizziness," I develop two of Plato's key strategies for dealing with dizziness in a healthy way, one that does not involve projection or falling into dogmatisms, and hence allows inquiry to continue. My reading, if compelling, offer us a psychological lens to think about the metaphysical distinction between appearance and reality in Plato's work, and makes a contribution to contemporary debates about the psychology of inquiry.